

Stablecoin Credit Infrastructure for AI Agents

THESIS Businesses are delegating more commercial activity to AI agents and will increasingly fund that activity with credit rather than prefunded balances. A new category of stablecoin-based agentic lenders will emerge to provide that financing, alongside the infrastructure needed to underwrite and distribute it.

OPPORTUNITY

Businesses are beginning to delegate purchasing and other financial activity to AI agents, moving a growing share of digital expenditure into machine-to-machine workflows. Stablecoins are already being used as the settlement asset because they can support continuous, low-value transactions without relying on traditional checkout infrastructure.

As agent activity scales, financing will need to move into the same workflow. Businesses cannot efficiently pre-fund large fleets of agents whose spending is variable and continuous. I believe this will create a new B2B market for stablecoin-based agentic lending, together with the underwriting, distribution, identity and risk infrastructure required to support it.

WHY NOW?

- 01 Stablecoins have reached commercial scale and are already being used in agent payments.** Total circulation exceeds \$300 billion, while Circle reported that 99.3% of x402 agent-payment volume settled in USDC in Q2 2026.
- 02 On-chain lending already provides a meaningful capital base.** Outstanding loans across major DeFi protocols reached \$26.1B in August 2026, up nearly 30% since June.
- 03 The infrastructure for agent finance is being built.** Coinbase launched Agentic Wallets with programmable spending limits, x402 surpassed 205M transactions by August 2026, and ERC-8004 is establishing standards for agent identity and reputation.
- 04 Credit is entering agent workflows.** Cred Protocol introduced deferred API payments, while t54's Claw Credit enables agents to purchase APIs, data and compute using credit rather than prefunded balances.
- 05 Stablecoins now have a U.S. regulatory framework.** The GENIUS Act, signed in July 2025, established federal rules for payment stablecoins, giving businesses and financial institutions greater clarity around their use.

PROBLEM AND WHITESPACE

- 01** Agent payment infrastructure has developed faster than agent financing. Businesses can give agents cards or wallets, but credit is still arranged outside the agent workflow or replaced with prefunded balances.
- 02** Corporate cards work for conventional purchases but are poorly suited to machine-native payments that can occur continuously and in very small amounts. Stablecoin rails solve the transaction problem, but the wallet still needs funding. A conventional fiat credit line introduces a separate conversion and settlement step before the agent can spend. The financing layer therefore needs to be integrated with the asset and workflow the agent already uses.
- 03** On-chain lending provides substantial available capital, but existing markets are largely designed around crypto collateral rather than underwriting the operating businesses generating agent expenditure. The capital exists, but the credit product connecting it to business activity does not.
- 04** Existing on-chain risk and identity tools focus primarily on wallets, transactions or agent-level behavior. Larger credit facilities require lenders to connect that activity to the underlying business, its repayment capacity and the authority delegated to each agent.

KEY RISKS

- 01 Existing credit is good enough.** Focus on use cases where stablecoins materially improve payment or funding economics.
- 02 Agent spend stays too small.** Target recurring, capital-intensive categories such as compute and infrastructure.
- 03 Agent data adds little to underwriting.** Keep business-level credit analysis at the core.
- 04 Institutional funding is slow.** Build around structures that meet lender risk and compliance requirements.

MARKET MAP

Companies referenced in this thesis

A AGENTIC LENDERS

t54t54Claw Credit

Cred ProtocolDeferred API payments

B PLATFORMS & MARKETPLACES

Wallets & agent platforms

Marketplaces, unannounced

C CREDIT INTELLIGENCE

Cred Protocol

Chainalysis

Agenticsc.credit

TRM Labs

D IDENTITY, PERMISSIONS & PRIVACY

zkMe

Canton

Privado ID

RAILS & STANDARDS

CircleUSDC

x402x402Agent payments

CoinbaseCoinbaseAgentic Wallets

ERC-8004ERC-8004Agent identity

USGENIUS ActUSStablecoin law

WHERE COMPANIES WILL BUILD

Stablecoin-based agentic credit will create opportunities across direct lending and enabling infrastructure.

A Agentic lenders

Stablecoin-native lenders will originate facilities that businesses can make available directly to AI agents, allowing credit to be drawn as expenditure occurs rather than continuously prefunded. Stablecoins fit this use case because they support small, frequent payments and can connect borrower demand to both institutional capital and existing pools of on-chain liquidity. t54's Claw Credit is an early example, financing API and compute purchases at the transaction level, while other providers are privately developing similar products around recurring compute and infrastructure usage.

I expect agentic lending to expand from transaction-level credit into broader working-capital and receivables financing as agent-driven business activity scales. The lenders that succeed will need underwriting and governance standards that attract institutional capital without imposing structures so restrictive that they lose the flexibility and liquidity available on-chain.

B Embedded credit platforms and marketplaces

Business lending marketplaces already aggregate fragmented credit supply rather than lend from their own balance sheets. Agentic platforms can apply the same model to stablecoin credit. Dedicated marketplaces can compare facilities from agentic lenders, while existing wallets and agent platforms can add credit distribution to an established customer base. This gives businesses one interface for financing instead of requiring separate integrations with each lender.

From conversations with several crypto companies, lending marketplaces with agent-credit features are in development but not yet announced. As stablecoin-native lenders increase, I expect these platforms to become the routing layer for agent credit, with the strongest positions held by companies that combine broad lender access with distribution inside agent workflows.

C On-chain credit intelligence

Established fintech lenders and private credit firms will enter stablecoin-based agentic lending, but they will be slower to build the required on-chain underwriting capabilities internally. Legacy systems, compliance constraints, and regulatory uncertainty will create urgency to rely on external providers. This follows an existing pattern, with financial institutions already using firms such as Chainalysis and TRM Labs to interpret on-chain activity.

Existing blockchain analytics firms will naturally extend into credit, and new platforms are being built around on-chain credit intelligence, though focused on wallet and transaction data. Cred Protocol provides on-chain scoring and reporting for AI agents, while Agenticsc.credit scores autonomous trading agents using verifiable wallet performance and distributes those assessments through APIs and partner integrations. As stablecoin-based agentic lending grows, these providers will become an external risk layer for lenders entering the market.

D Identity, permissions and privacy

Institutional activity on public blockchains is already constrained by confidentiality, contributing to the adoption of privacy-enabled networks such as Canton. Agentic lending adds another requirement because lenders must also verify which business controls an agent and what authority has been delegated to it.

Crypto-native providers such as zkMe and Privado ID are developing credentials that prove identity and permissions without publishing the underlying information on-chain. I expect this to become a required layer for institutional agentic lending, with the strongest providers offering credentials that are reusable across lenders while preserving the commercial privacy businesses already expect from traditional finance.